TOUGHER FOR FRESHERS

India's young jobseekers are facing a more competitive and increasingly complex transition from education to employment

70%	Say securing a first job is harder today than it was three–five years ago
72%	Say entry-level roles frequently demand prior experience
61%	Rarely or almost never hear back after applying for jobs
20%	Had access to paid internships during their studies
14%	Expect their first job to align across role, company and location preferences

SOURCE INDEED'S FRESHER HIRING REPORT, JUNE 2026

MEETING THE CHALLENGE

- India needs to create an average of 7.85 million jobs annually until 2030 in the non-farm sector
- Even where jobs exist, skill gaps, low wages, poor working conditions create challenges
- Economic challenge of unemployment could turn into a social problem
- Centre organising Rozgar melas, considering common calendar for recruitment exams
- AI is increasingly leading to job losses, need for reskilling across sectors
- Large number of youth not in education, employment and training



PHOTO BY **ARUN KUMAR**

in individuals' engagement with schooling, skill acquisition and employment," the PLFS report noted. ILO says NEET shows the progress in the effective integration of young people into the world of work.

A recent report by federal thinktank NITI Aayog had pegged the absolute number of those in NEET youth at 87 million based on the NSS 78th Round, which was collected during the Covid-19 pandemic (FY 2020–21). "...the youth NEET percentage is significantly lower in the most recent PLFS round 2025," the government later underlined.

More recent data on district-level labour market statistics revealed that a high population of youth in nearly a fourth of 250 districts was not gainfully employed or in education or training. In all, 23.7% of districts recorded NEET rate above 30% for youth in the age group of 15-29 years, it revealed.

While there may be no magic bullet that will suddenly wipe away this problem, the youth protests of 2026, however, make it clear that from being just an economic problem, unemployment could become a social one as well.

What's more, India's demographic dividend is slowly ending. A report by Moodys' Ratings says India is expected to move from an "aged" to a "super-aged" society in 16 years. "Although India's population is relatively young, fertility has already fallen below replacement and the country's age structure is beginning to shift, setting the stage for a much older population later this century," it warned. The clock is ticking. Finding quality jobs for citizens will not only fuel aspirations but can also keep the economy's growth engines firing over the next decades! BT

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